

Be the Helper



BIG IDEA Friends are usually the first to know. You do not have to be a counselor, you cannot fix everything alone, and you should not keep a serious secret by yourself. Hear, Help, Hand off.

1 HOOK 2'

2 ACTIVITY 8'

3 DISCUSS 3'

4 TAKEAWAY 2'

PREP IN 5 MINUTES

Materials: R8 Friend-Message Cards (six), Helper Card, Escalation Ladder (Green, Amber, Red) and Observer Card per triad; Workbook W8; a Helpline Card per student. Use no real chat screenshots.

- ☐ Print one R8 set per triad and a Helpline Card per student.
- ☐ Board: HEAR, HELP, HAND OFF.
- ☐ Counselor available; expect a student to disclose their own struggle or a friend's.

1 HOOK 2 MIN 60-second script Say: "When teens have a problem online, who do they tell first? Usually a friend. That makes you the first responder, and nobody trained you. That is a lot to carry. So today you get a simple way to be useful without being a hero. **Hear:** listen and believe, no blame. **Help:** do the small, safe things. **Hand off:** bring in a trusted adult, because you are not the only support, and you should not be. Hand off is no betrayal. It is what loyal friends do."

3 DISCUSS 3 MIN

- 1 "What was easiest about Hear? What was hardest?"
- 2 "What does it feel like when a friend asks you to keep a secret that scares you? What is a loyal response?"
- 3 "How do you tell Green, Amber and Red apart? What if you are not sure?"

FUN BOOST Calm Sort. Sort four extra low-weight cards Green, Amber or Red. "A friend says they feel like a burden" is Red; ask directly, stay, bring in an adult.

LEVEL-UP Three Registers. Write your Hand-off sentence as a text, as something you say in person, and as a note.

2 ACTIVITY 8 MIN Helper Role-Play

- 1 **(2 min) The model** for triads (Friend, Helper, Observer). **HEAR:** "Thank you for telling me." "That sounds really hard." "That is not your fault." **HELP:** stay with them, save details (never images), help them find a trusted adult and report; do not investigate, confront, post a call-out or forward screenshots. **HAND OFF:** "I care about you too much to keep this just between us. I will go with you." Ladder: **Green** a rough day (listen, check in later); **Amber** threats, blackmail, control, an image shared without consent (adult within 24 hours); **Red** self-harm talk, danger, abuse, a weapon (adult now; 988 or 911).
- 2 **(3 min) Round 1.** The Friend draws a card and reads it (F1 a blackmail threat, F2 "I do not want to be here anymore," F3 a partner took my phone, F4 a fake of me in a group chat, F5 the chat is piling on me, F6 I clicked a link and entered my password). The Helper practices Hear and Help and says the Hand off sentence. The Observer ticks the checklist.
- 3 **(3 min) Round 2.** Rotate roles; new card. Listen for the Hand off sentence. On F2 the Helper asks directly ("Are you thinking about hurting yourself?"), stays, and brings an adult now or calls or texts 988.

4 TAKEAWAY 2 MIN "Pause: do not react with blame. Check how big this is on the Ladder. Tell: hand off to a trusted adult, and look after yourself too. You do not have to carry this alone. Add to your Defense Plan: 'My Hand off adult is ____ and my sentence is ____'."

Hand signal: Hackles up? Noticing that a friend's message feels off is the first step of helping (hand brushed up the neck, optional). Post it: "Hear. Help. Hand off. Do not carry it alone."

EXIT TICKET "Write the three words of the plan and the sentence you would use for Hand off."

DIFFERENTIATE Give sentence strips for Hear, Help and Hand off; the Friend may read a card without improvising; use a smaller group with a counselor or aide.

FAMILY CARD Ask: "If a friend ever told you something scary, who would you tell?" In a crisis, call or text 988; 911 for immediate danger. Thank your teen if they bring you a friend's problem.

IF A STUDENT TELLS YOU SOMETHING

- **Say:** "Thank you for telling me. You did the right thing, and you are not in trouble."
- "I am glad you trusted me."
- "I want to get the right people to help, and I will stay with you while we do."
- **Do not say:** "Are you sure?" "That is not so bad." "Don't tell anyone."
- Do not promise secrecy or leave the student alone.
- Do not discuss methods or details of self-harm.

First 10 Minutes: see the Disclosure Guide.

Then: talk of self-harm: stay with the student, call or text 988 or 911. Tell your counselor or designated person the same day; follow your school policy and your state's reporting law.